



'U Wanna Angles... U Wanna Fly', acrylic on canvas by Satadru Sanyal; Courtesy Religare Arts | Gallery

WE NEED TO ELABORATE A NATIONALISM THAT PROCEEDS BY COMPOSITION, NOT BY IMPOSITION; THAT IS INDUCTIVE AND ADDITIVE, NOT DEDUCTIVE AND SUBTRACTIVE.

electoral benefits. To some extent, of course, they did, but in doing so, the limits of their running-scared nationalism were revealed.

Hindutva nationalism was a zero-sum nationalism: its promised gains were always at the expense of others. The BJP somehow imagined that it could gull Indians into believing that this was a unifying nationalism. But over time it became clear that most Indians perceived the BJP's nationalism as divisive, disruptive and undesirable.

In some respects, the BJP was quite right to say, in 2004, that India was 'shining'—after all, growth rates were unprecedented, the numbers in poverty were declining. Yet the movement's ideological narrative remained trapped by its exclusivist, defensive posture: for all its faux aggressiveness, it continued to portray India and its Hindus as victims.

The dissonance in the BJP's message defeated its electoral prospects in 2004. But the party an-

ticipated electoral dividends after last year's long sequence of terrorist attacks last year, culminating in the assault on Mumbai. It could not realise these hopes in 2009. It had wrongly imagined a fearful, defensive electorate. Its rhetoric simply did not resonate. It could not expand its support among young voters.

India's incumbent leadership, meanwhile, has done better by defining its political vision in terms of economic development and social justice. A steady focus on these issues over the past five years has allowed for a valuable break from the incendiary identity battles that have scarred the recent political landscape.

But, in the years ahead, we are going to need a political vision more gripping than merely the economistic—one that manages to articulate the optimism and pride in Indianness. Paradoxically, the most important large-scale change has been the emergence of the states, both as

According to the 2001 Census, Bengali, Telugu and Marathi, in that order, are the most spoken languages after Hindi, spoken by 8.11, 7.19 and 6.99 per cent of the population respectively.